

Cryptographic Facilities in Unicon

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Abstract

Unicon has long used OpenSSL for encrypted network sockets, but hashing, HMAC, signing, and symmetric encryption were not available as language primitives. This report describes the facilities that close that gap: cryptographic operations reached through the same `open()`, `read()`, `write()`, `close()`, and `Attrib()` interface already used for files, sockets, and SSH sessions. Mode letter `e` is reused as a modifier; `op=` selects the operation; keys and certificates are loaded as file-typed handles and passed as attributes. Encrypted TCP is unchanged; encrypted UDP uses DTLS. The implementation is the OpenSSL EVP interface already linked for TLS. Keywords: Unicon, cryptography, OpenSSL, TLS, DTLS, hash, HMAC, sign, encrypt, runtime, technical report.

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1 1. Introduction

This report describes the cryptographic facilities in the Unicon runtime: how a handle is opened, how payload flows through `write()` / `read()`, how key and certificate material is loaded and reused, and how the same letters and attributes compose with encrypted sockets. It is formatted as a Unicon Technical Report [1]. The language-facing reference lives in *Programming with Unicon* (Chapter 6) and the language reference (open modes `e` / `er` / `eh` / `re` / `we`, and `ne` / `nue`). Automated tests live under `tests/crypto/`.

The feature is optional in the same sense as TLS. A build with OpenSSL reports `secure sockets layer encryption` in `&features` (the `_SSL` flag). Without the library, the crypto paths are compiled out. There is no separate `-disable-crypto` switch; `-disable-ssl` turns off both encrypted sockets and these facilities.

2 2. Motivation

Unicon already links OpenSSL [4] for mode `n` with `e` – encrypted TCP. Programs that needed a SHA-256 digest, an HMAC, a signature, or a file encrypted at rest had to leave the language. The facilities here expose those primitives without a second API: hashing a stream is opening a handle and writing to it; reading an encrypted file is opening the file with a transform on the way through; loading a key once and signing many messages is the same pattern as opening an SSH session once and deriving channels [5].

No new external dependency is introduced. The implementation uses OpenSSL’s EVP interface, which the encrypted-socket support already requires.

3 3. Design principles

“e” is the crypto letter, reused not invented. Unicon already uses `e` for encryption (`Fs_Encrypt`). New modes carry that letter rather than adding one letter per operation. `op=` selects what the handle does.

“e” composes as a modifier. Mode letters already stack, and several already branch on bits accumulated so far: `n + e` is an encrypted socket; `r + e` / `w + e` is a file transform; `e + h` is an in-memory hash; `e + r` is raw key material rather than a path.

The open target configures the operation; payload is I/O. Target is never the message being hashed or encrypted. What target means depends on the mode (algorithm name, key path, data file, host:port). Payload always flows through `write()` / `read()` / `reads()`.

Attributes are “name=value” strings, or handles. A string element is parsed as always. A **handle** – the return value of a prior `open(..., "e")` – is a typed attribute that could not survive being flattened into a string. Handles are interpreted by **role** from their own content (private key, public key, cert, symmetric key), not by position or by an attribute name.

Material comes from a file, raw bytes, or a handle. A file path is the target under mode `e`, or `key=` when the target is already spoken for (`re` / `we`, `n + e`). Raw bytes use mode `er`. A handle avoids re-parsing.

Initialization is lazy. `open()` does not create the underlying EVP context until the first `write()` (or the first transforming `read()` on a file). A handle that is never used costs nothing. `read()` finalizes and resets, so the next `write()` initializes again.

“Attrib()” reconfigures only in the idle window – before the first `write()`, or after a `read()` and before the next `write()`. Changing `op=`, `alg=`, `cipher=`, or `iv=` mid-operation fails. Handles are accepted by `open()` only, not by `Attrib()`: `Attrib()` already treats a file argument as a retarget.

4 4. Modes

`open()`’s mode string is scanned character by character in `src/runtime/fsys.r`. Letters are not independent: `u` after `n` is UDP, `r` after `n` is raw, `h` after `e` is hash. Order matters. `e` already set `Fs_Encrypt`; this design adds `Fs_Crypto` for hash / HMAC / sign / verify / encrypt-decrypt handles so they are distinct from TLS sockets that also carry `Fs_Encrypt`.

Mode	Meaning	Target
<code>e</code>	Load material, or an operation whose target is material	Key/cert path, or a mate
<code>er</code>	Same, but the target is raw bytes	In-memory string
<code>eh</code>	Hash; no <code>op=</code> needed	Digest name, e.g. <code>sha256</code>
<code>re</code>	Read a file, transformed (hash or decrypt)	Data-file path
<code>we</code>	Write a file, transformed (encrypt)	Data-file path
<code>ne</code>	Encrypted TCP (TLS) – unchanged	<code>host:port</code>
<code>nue</code> / <code>naue</code>	Encrypted UDP (DTLS)	<code>host:port</code>

e / **er** are the **data-pipe** shape: write payload in, read the result out. **eh** is separate because its target is an algorithm name, never material. **re** / **we** are the **file-transform** shape: the target is the data file, so key material arrives via **key=** or a handle attribute.

h alone remains SSH. **r** alone remains read. The new meanings apply only when **e** was seen first.

Mode - skips peer verification on TLS (**ne-**) and SSH (**h-**), the same as **verifyPeer=no**. An explicit **verifyPeer=** overrides the mode flag.

5 5. Operations

op= names the operation when the mode does not already imply one. Loading material (**e** / **er** with a file or raw target and no **op=**), hashing in memory (**eh**), and TLS / DTLS sockets take no **op=**.

op=	What it does	Typical mode	Other attributes
hash	Digest of a file	re	alg=
hmac	Keyed digest (RFC 2104)	e / er	alg=
sign	Produce a signature	e / er	alg=
verify	Check a signature	e / er	alg= , sig=
encrypt	Symmetric encrypt	e / er , or we	cipher= ; key= or a handle for we
decrypt	Symmetric decrypt	e / er , or re	cipher= ; key= or a handle for re

HMAC is the construction of RFC 2104 [6] over the digest named by **alg=**. Algorithm and cipher names are OpenSSL's own (**sha256**, **aes-256-gcm**) and are passed through rather than mapped to a Unicon-defined set.

Defaults are **alg=sha256** and **cipher=aes-256-gcm**.

6 6. Attributes

Trailing **open()** arguments are **name=value** strings or crypto handles. Empty values and unknown names fail (TLS attribute errors use 1302; crypto state/name mistakes use 1316).

6.1 6.1 TLS / DTLS attributes

These are the names `create_ssl_context()` accepts. They apply to `ne` / `nue` and are unchanged except for the two alignments in [section 6.3](#).

Attribute	Meaning
<code>cert=</code>	Certificate file path
<code>key=</code>	Private key file path
<code>keypass=</code>	Passphrase for an encrypted private key
<code>ca=</code> / <code>caDir=</code> / <code>caStore=</code>	Trust store
<code>ciphers=</code> / <code>ciphers1.3=</code>	TLS 1.2 (and earlier) list, and TLS 1.3 suites
<code>minProto=</code> / <code>maxProto=</code>	Protocol version bounds, e.g. TLS1.2
<code>verifyPeer=</code>	<code>yes</code> / <code>no</code> ; <code>no</code> is the same as mode -

Socket attributes (`reuseaddr`, `ttl`, `iface`, `join`, `proto`, ...) are applied separately and are unaffected.

6.2 6.2 Crypto attributes

Attribute	Meaning	Used with
<code>op=</code>	Operation name	All data-pipe and file
<code>alg=</code>	Digest / signature algorithm (default <code>sha256</code>)	<code>hash</code> , <code>hmac</code> , <code>sign</code> , <code>ver</code>
<code>cipher=</code>	Symmetric cipher (default <code>aes-256-gcm</code>)	<code>encrypt</code> , <code>decrypt</code>
<code>iv=</code>	Explicit IV; omit for automatic IV	<code>encrypt</code> , <code>decrypt</code>
<code>sig=</code>	Signature being checked	<code>verify</code>
<code>key=</code>	Key path when the target is already a data file or host	<code>re</code> / <code>we</code> , and TLS
<code>type=</code>	Narrow a multi-item file: <code>cert</code> , <code>key</code> , <code>pubkey</code>	Material load (<code>e</code> / <code>er</code>)
<code>keypass=</code>	Passphrase for an encrypted key file	Material load
<code>state</code> / <code>state=</code>	Digest checkpoint; not available with OpenSSL 3	<code>hash</code> , <code>hmac</code>

`key=` on a crypto handle is typed by content and by the operation: PEM / DER private keys for `sign` and TLS; raw bytes for `encrypt`, `decrypt`, and `hmac`. A role mismatch fails rather than guessing.

Without `iv=`, `encrypt` generates a fresh random IV per operation and prepends it to the ciphertext; `decrypt` reads that prefix. Supplying `iv=` opts out – useful for a wire format that does not prepend an IV, or for test vectors – and hands uniqueness back to the caller. The default cipher is AEAD; the runtime appends the authentication tag after the ciphertext.

`Attrib(h, "type")` reports the material role (`symkey`, `key`, `cert`, ...). `Attrib(h, "state")` is the designed checkpoint for resuming a hash across a process break: it snapshots in-progress digest state without finalizing or resetting. The blob is **opaque and not portable** (OpenSSL version and provider), must be restored into the same algorithm, and for `hmac` is key-equivalent secret material (length-extension). Ordinary streaming does not need it. OpenSSL 3 removed the `MD_CTX` export APIs, so the operation currently fails with 1316.

6.3 Shared names with SSH

`key=` is a private-key path on TLS, crypto, and SSH. `keypass=` is the shared name for a key-file passphrase. SSH `password=` is the remote login password and is not accepted on TLS. Crypto still accepts `password=` as an alias for `keypass=`.

`verifyPeer=yes|no` and `mode -` mean the same thing on TLS and SSH. An explicit `verifyPeer=` overrides the mode flag. Trust stores stay distinct: TLS uses `ca=` (X.509); SSH uses `hostkeyfile=` (OpenSSH `known_hosts`).

7. Material handles

Mode `e` with no `op=` loads keys and certificates. Content is auto-detected (PEM by header, DER by probe-by-parse). A file that holds several items – a combined `cert+key` PEM, or a `cert` plus chain – loads into one handle. `type=` narrows that to a single role.

```
k := open("signing.pem", "e")
pk := open("verify.pem", "e")
c := open("client.pem", "e")
kb := open(key_bytes, "er")
ek := open("enc.key", "e", "keypass=" || pw)
c := open("bundle.pem", "e", "type=cert")
```

Material split across files can be merged:

```
idh := open("client.pem", "e")
Attrib(idh, "key=client.key")
```

A handle is a file value (`type(h)` is `"file"`) carrying `Fs_Crypto`, the same way a window or socket is a file that does not support every file operation. The underlying `CryptoFile` is malloc'd, like `SSHfile`, so pointers stay stable across garbage collection and are freed by `close()`.

Consumers ask a handle for the roles they need. An encrypted socket wants a cert and a private key: one merged handle satisfies both, or two handles each contribute what they have. `op=sign` wants a private key; `op=hmac` wants symmetric bytes. A missing role, or two handles supplying the same role, fails at `open()` rather than later at `write()`.

Handles appear only among `open()` attributes, not `Attrib()`. Binding material is an open-time concern; `Attrib()` already uses a file argument to retarget which socket the following names apply to.

`open(k, "e", "op=sign")` derives an operation from a material handle. A graphics-style `clone()` would give that verb a single meaning, but would be a second mechanism next to the handle attributes that TLS and `re` / `we` need anyway.

8 8. Examples

These assume a build with `secure sockets layer encryption`. Failures set `&errortext`; the usual form is `h := open(...) | stop(&errortext)`. Package `crypto` (`uni/lib/crypto.icn`) supplies `hexencode` / `hexbytes` and `base64` helpers for dumping binary digests and keys.

8.1 8.1 Hash

```
h := open("sha256", "eh")
write(h, msg)
digest := read(h)
close(h)
```

`write()` may be called many times; `read()` finalizes the digest **and re-sets** the handle, so the same handle can hash unrelated messages:

```
h := open("sha256", "eh")
write(h, msg1)
d1 := read(h)
```



```

write(h, msg2)
write(h, msg3)
d2 := read(h)
read(h)           # fails -- nothing written since last read()
close(h)

```

A whole file uses the file-transform shape:

```

h := open("bigfile.dat", "re", "op=hash", "alg=sha256")
digest := read(h)
close(h)

```

The first `read()` consumes the file and returns the digest; a second fails.

8.2 8.2 HMAC

```

k := open("hmac.key", "e")
hm := open(k, "e", "op=hmac", "alg=sha256")
every msg := !messages do {
  write(hm, msg)
  mac := read(hm)
}
close(hm)

```

Raw key bytes use mode `er`:

```

hm := open(hmac_key_bytes, "er", "op=hmac", "alg=sha256")
write(hm, msg)
mac := read(hm)

```

8.3 8.3 Sign and verify

```

k := open("signing.pem", "e")
sg := open(k, "e", "op=sign", "alg=sha256")
write(sg, msg)
signature := read(sg)
close(sg)

```

```
pk := open("verify.pem", "e")
vf := open(pk, "e", "op=verify", "alg=sha256", "sig=" || signature)
write(vf, msg)
read(vf) | stop("bad signature: ", &errortext)
close(vf)
```

A failed verify sets `&errornumber` 1315 so it is distinct from "nothing written." The same handle can check many messages by setting `sig=` in the idle window:

```
pk := open("verify.pem", "e")
vf := open(pk, "e", "op=verify", "alg=sha256")
every m := !messages do {
  Attrib(vf, "sig=" || m.signature)
  write(vf, m.body)
  if read(vf) then
    ok(m)
  else if &errornumber = 1315 then
    bad(m)
  else
    stop("nothing written")
}
close(vf)
```

8.4 8.4 Symmetric encrypt and decrypt

```
ky := open("aes.key", "e")
enc := open(ky, "e", "op=encrypt")
write(enc, plaintext)
ciphertext := read(enc)

Attrib(enc, "op=decrypt")
write(enc, ciphertext)
recovered := read(enc)
close(enc)
close(ky)
```

The idle-window `Attrib(..., "op=decrypt")` reuses the bound key. With no `iv=`, each `read()` generates a fresh IV and prepends it, so one handle can encrypt many messages:

```

c := open(ky, "e", "op=encrypt")
every plaintext := !messages do {
  write(c, plaintext)
  ciphertext := read(c)
}

```

For a wire format that does not prepend an IV, or for test vectors, set `iv=` in the idle window and take uniqueness yourself:

```

every plaintext := !messages do {
  Attrib(c, "iv=" || newiv())
  write(c, plaintext)
  ciphertext := read(c)
}

```

8.5 8.5 File encrypt and decrypt

```

f := open("secrets.dat", "we", "op=encrypt", "key=aes.key")
writes(f, plaintext)
close(f)

f := open("secrets.dat", "re", "op=decrypt", "key=aes.key")
pending := []
while chunk := reads(f, 4096) do put(pending, chunk)
if &errornumber then
  stop("tampered: ", &errortext)
close(f)

```

Writes encrypt and are finalized on `close()`. Reads decrypt as a stream. AEAD authentication is checked on the **final** read: earlier `reads()` chunks are provisional. Nothing decrypted should be acted on until the stream completes without error. Callers who cannot defer processing should use the data-pipe shape, where a single `read()` returns plaintext only after the tag verifies.

The same key handle can wrap many files:

```

keyh := open("aes.key", "e")
every name := !filenames do {

```

```
f := open(name || ".enc", "we", "op=encrypt", keyh)
write(f, contents(name))
close(f)
}
```

8.6 TLS identity reuse and DTLS

Encrypted TCP remains "ne". Material handles may be passed as attributes so certs and keys are parsed once. The socket asks by role, not by position: one combined PEM, or two handles, both work.

```
id := open("client.pem", "e")
conn := open("host:443", "ne", id, "verifyPeer=no")
conn := open("host:443", "ne-", id)    # same as verifyPeer=no

certh := open("client.pem", "e")
keyh  := open("client.key", "e")
conn  := open("host:443", "ne", certh, keyh)
```

Encrypted UDP (DTLS) uses "nue" / "naue". The runtime selects a DTLS context when the socket is datagram.

9 I/O and `Attrib()`

On a data-pipe handle, `write()` accumulates and `read()` finalizes. `read()` is always terminal – one read consumes the whole result and resets the handle – for two reasons that are easy to forget later. First, the default cipher is AEAD (aes-256-gcm): nothing authenticated can be released until the tag is checked at the end, so a mid-stream plaintext read would be a lie. Second, `read()` already means "finalize and reset" for hash / HMAC / sign; a partial encrypt read would look identical to a final one, and the handle would reset under the caller. Block ciphers such as CBC or CTR *could* emit ciphertext at a block boundary, but that would be a second meaning of `read()` next to the AEAD and digest rules, so it is not offered. A second `read()` with nothing written since the last one fails, as when reading a socket with no data. `close()` is idempotent: a second `close()`, or `close()` on a never-written handle, releases the handle and drops its reference to any bound key.

On `we`, writes encrypt to the file and `close()` flushes the AEAD tag. On `re` with `op=decrypt`, `reads()` yields plaintext chunks. On `re` with `op=hash`, the first `read()` returns the digest.

`Attrib()` during the idle window may change `op=`, `alg=`, `cipher=`, `iv=`, and `sig=`. A change while a digest or cipher is in flight fails (1316). `Attrib(h, "type")` is a query. Handles are not valid `Attrib()` values.

Framing is owned by the runtime: IV prepended, tag appended, both fixed-length per cipher. The same layout is used for `e` / `er` output and for `we` files.

10 10. Error handling

Crypto and TLS connect failures **fail**, they do not **runerr**. This matches the SSL connect path: set `&errortext`, tear down what was allocated, and fail, so callers write `if h := open(...) then ... else ....` Runtime errors are reserved for type mistakes (a bad mode letter, a non-file where a handle is required).

Error numbers, defined in `src/runtime/data.r`:

Number	Text	Typical cause
1300–1308	SSL / certificate / cipher errors	TLS context and handshake
1311	unknown cryptographic algorithm or cipher	Bad <code>alg=</code> or <code>cipher=</code>
1312	cryptographic handle lacks required material	Missing key, cert, or wrong role
1313	duplicate cryptographic material role	Two handles both supply the same role
1314	AEAD authentication failed	Tampered or truncated ciphertext
1315	signature verification failed	<code>op=verify</code> did not match
1316	invalid cryptographic operation state	Mid-operation <code>Attrib()</code> , bad <code>op=</code> , etc.
1317	cryptographic material could not be loaded	Unreadable path, parse failure, allocation failure

11 11. Build integration

Crypto compiles under `HAVE_LIBSSL`, the same guard as TLS. `configure -disable-ssl` turns both off. `-enable-thin` disables SSL as part of a minimal build. Otherwise `CHECK_OPENSSL` probes for the library and headers.

`&features` reports `secure sockets layer encryption. tests/crypto/Makefile` skips the suite when that string is absent. TLS echo tests also require `concurrent threads`.

Guards are `#if HAVE_LIBSSL` in `rstructs.h`, `rmacros.h`, `feature.h`, `fsys.r`, `fmisc.r`, `rposix.r`, and `rcrypto.ri`. TLS helpers (`create_ssl_context`, `is_ssl_attr`) and the `CryptoFile` implementation share `src/runtime/rcrypto.ri`.

12 12. Status and remaining work

The language surface described here is implemented: modes `e` / `er` / `eh` / `re` / `we`, TLS handle reuse, DTLS context selection and handshake, `keypass=` / `verifyPeer=` alignment with SSH, and the error numbers in [section 10](#).

Digest checkpoint. `Attrib(h, "state") / state=` is part of the design for resuming a hash across a process break ([section 6.2](#)). OpenSSL 3 removed the `MD_CTX` export APIs, so the operation fails with 1316. Ordinary streaming does not need it.

Separate configure switch. Crypto cannot be compiled out while leaving TLS sockets on. A `Unicon_Crypto` / `NoCrypto` guard driven by `-disable-crypto` is the obvious next step if a distribution wants encrypted sockets without the new `open()` modes.

`“~“` in `“key=“`. Not expanded, matching SSH. Callers must expand a leading `~/` themselves.

Asymmetric encrypt / decrypt. The `op=` set is hash, HMAC, sign, verify, and symmetric encrypt/decrypt. Public-key encryption is not exposed.

Trust-on-first-use and key generation are out of scope. Certificates and keys are created out of band.

13 Appendix: test coverage

Automated tests live under `tests/crypto/`, one program per concern: `hash`, `hmac`, `sha512`, `sign`, `encrypt`, `iv`, `freshiv`, `tamper`, `filehash`, `filecrypt`, `filekey`, `filekeyattr`, `filetamper`, `opswitch`, `midattrib`, `badalg`, `badkey`, `badrole`, `badstate`, `badverify`, plus TLS / DTLS (`tlspain`, `tlsverify`, `tlsauth`, `tlsproto`, `tlscipher`, `tlshandle`, `dtls`, `dtlsecho`). `tests/crypto/Makefile` skips the suite when OpenSSL is absent, and skips the threaded TLS echo tests when concurrency is absent. Expected output is `tests/crypto/stand/*.std`.

14 References

References

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